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The web of kinship among the Tallensi

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This undertone of deference is also present in intercourse with the father, only less obviously than in relation to the mother. For instance, if a child is some distance away and its father or mother wants to call it, he or she will shout the child's name. But if a child, even when grown up, wishes to call a parent he will go up to him or her. A boy or a man will borrow his brother's cloth without asking permission. He will not take anything belonging to his father without permission. If two brothers or sisters or a sister and brother are eating together either will start first and both may be dipping their hands into the dish of porridge at the same time. If a child is eating with his parent he will wait for his parent to begin first and to tell him to eat, and will wait for his parent to finish and leave the dish to be 'cleaned out (*veeh*)' by him. In particular, the familiarity between parents and children never goes so far as mutual teasing, as in a joking relationship. If a native is asked about this he frowns and says that it would be most offensive for a son or daughter to tease or joke with (*kooh*) a parent or vice versa. You cannot tease or joke with your parent or your child, the Tallensi say, because you do so with your grandparent or grandchild. We shall return to this presently.

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We see, again, that there is an apparent paradox in the relations of Tale parents and children. The natives cannot explain it and are puzzled if they are asked for explanations. But if we take into account the whole complex of parent-child relations an interpretation is possible. What we meet again is that ever-recurring principle of Tale social organization, the conjunction of polar forces, the synthesis of tendencies that work in opposite directions. The sense of continuity between the generations, which is so strong among the Tallensi, has to be reconciled with the sense of divergence due to differences

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of generation and of interests between them, if the relations of parents and children are to run smoothly. In terms of sentiments and attitudes the authority parents have over their children must be reconciled with their love for them; and children must be able to show respect for their parents, to bow to their control, without ceasing to love them and without foregoing their own independence. Children are the fulfilment of their parents' life—and at the same time felt to be in some way their parents' rivals. Parents suffer and spend themselves to give life to their child. They provide for him and fix his place in society. But he can never escape from their constraint. In all their relations with each other parents and children have to cope with actually or potentially conflicting motives and sentiments as well as with the pull and pressure of divergent social forces.

The familiarity and friendliness between parents and children in their everyday relations is one of the means by which these diverse  198 tendencies are reconciled. The liberty to address his father by name is a reassurance, to the child, of the love and solicitude that lie behind the authority his father exercises over him. Perhaps it is also an expression of the identification of father and child by the lineage principle. And the greater deference in his behaviour towards his mother than towards his father is a sign that he recognizes her control, though she seems to have only love and devotion for him. Familiarity in everyday intercourse compensates for the filial piety due to a parent in the more formal, particularly in the jural and ritual aspects, of parent-child relations. The greater overt freedom with the father compensates for the greater emphasis on respect and dependence in the child's relations with him; the franker signs of deference towards the mother compensate for the greater emphasis on her love for her child as against her authority over him.

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